

Education & Learning

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NOUNS

degree

a qualification awarded by a university after completing a course of study

She has a degree in economics from the University of Barcelona.

exam

a formal test of knowledge or ability

She passed all her exams with top marks.

grades

marks awarded for academic work or exams

Her grades improved significantly after she started tutoring.

lecture

a formal talk given to a group of students at a university

The lecture on climate policy was standing room only.

dissertation

a long piece of academic writing on a specific topic, usually for a degree

She spent a year researching and writing her dissertation.

tenure

the right to hold a permanent academic position

She was granted tenure after ten years of research and publishing.

autodidact

a person who is self-taught

He never went to university. He's a complete autodidact.

curriculum

the subjects and content taught in a school or course

The national curriculum has been updated to include coding.

tuition

teaching or instruction, especially at a university; also the fees charged

Tuition fees have risen dramatically in the last decade.

scholarship

a financial award given to a student based on academic merit or need

He won a scholarship to study abroad.

syllabus

a document outlining the topics covered in a course

The syllabus was published at the start of the semester.

pedagogy

the theory and practice of teaching

Modern pedagogy emphasises student-centred learning over rote memorisation.

meritocracy

a system in which advancement is based on ability and achievement

The university claims to be a meritocracy, but privilege still plays a role.

ADJECTIVES

compulsory

required by law or rule; mandatory

Maths and English are compulsory subjects until the age of sixteen.

academic

relating to education, schools, or scholarly work

Her academic record is outstanding.

gifted

having exceptional natural ability or talent

The programme is designed for gifted children who need extra challenge.

hands-on

involving practical experience rather than just theory

The course is very hands-on. You're in the workshop from day one.

rote

involving mechanical repetition without understanding

Rote learning can help with memorisation but not with critical thinking.

vocational

relating to practical skills and training for a specific job

Vocational courses in plumbing and electrical work are increasingly popular.

knowledgeable

having a lot of knowledge; well-informed

She's incredibly knowledgeable about European history.

VERBS

study

to spend time learning about a subject

She studied medicine at university for six years.

revise

to review and study material again in preparation for an exam

She revised for three weeks solid before the finals.

cram

to study intensively in a short period, usually just before an exam

He crammed the night before and somehow passed.

graduate

to successfully complete a degree or course of study

He graduated with honours in 2019.

enrol

to officially register for a course or institution

She enrolled on a part-time MBA programme.

nurture

to encourage and support the development of a skill or talent

Good teachers nurture curiosity rather than just delivering content.

PHRASAL VERBS

drop out

to leave a course or school before finishing

He dropped out of university in his second year.

pick up

to learn something informally and without deliberate study

He picked up Spanish just from living in Madrid.

fall behind

to fail to keep up with others in progress or work

He fell behind after missing a week of classes.

catch up

to reach the same level as others after falling behind

She missed two weeks and struggled to catch up.

brush up on

to improve or refresh knowledge or a skill you already have

She brushed up on her French before the trip to Paris.

knuckle down

to start working or studying hard and seriously

She knew she had to knuckle down if she wanted to pass.

COLLOCATIONS

sit an exam

to take or attempt a formal examination

She's sitting her final exams next month.

a steep learning curve

a situation where you have to learn a lot in a short time

Starting the new job was a steep learning curve but she adapted quickly.

lifelong learning

the habit of learning new things throughout your whole life, not just at school

The course is aimed at adults interested in lifelong learning.

learn by heart

to memorise something so you can repeat it exactly

We had to learn the poem by heart for homework.

gap year

a break, usually a year long, taken between finishing school and starting university, often spent travelling or working

He spent his gap year teaching English abroad before starting his course.

IDIOMS

pull an all-nighter

to stay up all night working or studying, usually just before a deadline or exam

I pulled an all-nighter before the final exam and could barely keep my eyes open the next morning.

hit the books

to begin studying hard

She hit the books as soon as the exam dates were announced.

teacher's pet

a student who is the teacher's favourite, often used negatively

He was always the teacher's pet, sat at the front and answered every question.

school of hard knocks

real-life experience rather than formal education

He didn't go to university. He graduated from the school of hard knocks.

MODERN SLANG

ace

to do extremely well in an exam, test, or interview

She walked out of the exam hall grinning, certain she'd aced it.

bunk off

to skip school or a class without permission (British informal)

He used to bunk off PE and hide in the toilets.

swot

a person who studies excessively; also to study hard (British informal)

She's such a swot. She's always in the library.